CASE CLASSIFICATION IN NVIVO

Assigning Demographic Attributes to Research Participants

Qualitative Data Analysis Software — Training Report

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Report type	Intern Training / Qualitative Research Report
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Subject	Creating and using case classification sheets in NVivo
Source material	Instructional video transcript (step-by-step demo)
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Note: Case classification sheets link coded qualitative data to participant demographics, enabling structured subgroup comparison within an NVivo project.

1. Introduction

In qualitative research software such as **NVivo**, **case classification** is the method used to assign demographic attributes — such as **gender, age, role, or location** — to specific participants or subjects in a research study. Each participant is treated as a "case," and each case is tagged with structured attribute values stored in a **classification sheet**.

By creating these classification sheets, researchers can organize project data to effectively **compare different subgroups**. For example, one might analyze how different age groups or genders perceive a specific topic such as environmental change. This report summarizes the concept, benefits, and the primary setup steps demonstrated in the source video.

2. Why Use Case Classification Sheets?

2.1 Subgroup Comparison

- Categorize subjects by specific traits — **gender, age, role, or location**.
- Compare how different groups respond to the research topic.

2.2 Analytical Depth

- Enable nuanced analysis — e.g., comparing the opinions of **40-year-old males** against **25-year-old females** on an issue such as environmental change.
- Move beyond overall themes to **demographically grounded interpretations**.

2.3 Organization

- Provide a **structured, efficient** way to manage participant data.
- Keep the project organized as **coded data is connected to demographic identifiers**.

3. Creating a Case Classification Sheet — Step by Step

The following five steps outline the primary setup procedure as demonstrated in the source video.

Step 1 — Locate the Navigation Pane

Navigate to the **Cases** group in the Navigation Pane, expand it, and select the **Case Classifications** folder.

Step 2 — Create the Classification

Right-click in the working area, select **New Classification**, and name your sheet (e.g., *Participant Demographics Sheet*).

Step 3 — Add Attributes

Right-click within the new table and select **New Attribute** to define demographic categories such as *Gender*, *Age*, or *Location*.

Step 4 — Define Attribute Values

Under the **Values** tab for each attribute, keep the default options (*Unassigned*, *Not Applicable*) and click **Add** to enter your specific custom values (e.g., *Male*, *Female*).

Step 5 — Manage Existing Attributes

If attributes already exist in other tables, use **Cut and Paste** to consolidate them into your new classification sheet.

4. Worked Example: A Participant Demographics Sheet

The table below illustrates how a completed classification sheet might be structured for a study examining perceptions of environmental change.

Attribute	Type	Example values
Gender	Text (predefined values)	Male, Female
Age	Integer / range	25, 40 (years)
Role	Text (predefined values)	Student, Professional, Retiree
Location	Text (predefined values)	Urban, Rural

With cases classified this way, a query in NVivo can compare coded responses — for instance, environmental-change themes raised by 40-year-old male participants versus 25-year-old female participants.

5. Key Takeaways for Interns

- ✔ A “case” in NVivo = one participant or subject; classification sheets store their demographic attributes.
- ✔ Plan attributes before coding: gender, age, role, and location are common starting points.
- ✔ Always keep the default values (Unassigned, Not Applicable) and add study-specific values via Add.
- ✔ Use Cut and Paste to consolidate attributes from other tables — don't rebuild them from scratch.
- ✔ Classify early: connecting coded data to demographics unlocks subgroup comparison for richer analysis.
- ✔ Example insight path: code → classify cases → run matrix/crosstab queries by demographic subgroup.

6. Conclusion

Case classification is a core NVivo competency for qualitative researchers. By assigning demographic attributes to participants through classification sheets, analysts can organize participant data systematically, keep projects structured as coding grows, and perform demographically grounded comparisons — such as contrasting the views of different age groups or genders on environmental change. The five-step setup procedure described in this report is quick to learn and immediately strengthens the analytical depth of any NVivo project.

7. Source

This report is prepared from the transcript of an instructional video demonstrating how to create and use case classification sheets in NVivo, including navigation steps, attribute and value definition, and the analytical benefits of subgroup comparison.